敦煌的修画人

沙漠里的一面墙和一个飞天

The Mural Restorers of Dunhuang

A wall in the desert and a flying apsara

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 莫高窟[1]的一个小洞窟[2]里，有一个飞天[3]。她没有翅膀[4]，只有一条长长的衣带，可是看她的人都觉得，她仿佛正在往天上飞。她已经这样飞了一千多年。画她的人叫什么名字，没有人知道。修她的人叫什么名字，大概以后也不会有人知道。这个故事，说的就是修她的人。

沙漠里的火车

2 林秋[5]第一次去敦煌[6]，是坐火车去的。那年夏天，她刚从南方一所美术学院毕业，学的是中国画[7]。同学们有的去了广告公司，有的去中学当了美术老师，有的开了自己的画室。只有她，报名参加了敦煌研究院[8]的招聘，要去沙漠里修壁画[9]。

1 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves, Dunhuang
2 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
3 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
4 翅膀 *chìbǎng* wing
5 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
6 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang, city in Gansu
7 中国画 *zhōngguóhuà* Chinese painting
8 敦煌研究院 *Dūnhuáng Yánjiūyuàn* Dunhuang Academy
9 壁画 *bìhuà* mural

In a small cave at Mogao there is a flying apsara. She has no wings, only a long ribbon, yet everyone who looks at her feels as if she is flying up into the sky. She has been flying like this for more than a thousand years. No one knows the name of the person who painted her. And the names of the people who repaired her will probably never be known either. This story is about the people who repaired her. 1

The Train in the Desert

The first time Lin Qiu went to Dunhuang, she went by train. That summer she had just graduated from an art academy in the south, where she had studied Chinese painting. Some of her classmates went to advertising companies, some became art teachers at middle schools, and some opened studios of their own. Only she applied to the Dunhuang Academy, to go and repair murals in the desert. 2

3 火车开出兰州[†]以后，妈妈又打来了电话。“秋秋[‡]，你现在后悔还来得及。”妈妈说，“就算你再喜欢画画，也不用跑到沙漠里去画呀。”林秋[§]笑着说：“妈，我不是去画画，是去修画。”“修画？那不就是画画吗？”林秋想了想，没有回答。其实她自己也不太清楚，这两件事到底有什么不同。

4 窗外的景色越来越单调。一开始还能看见一些村子和绿色的田地，后来就只剩下灰黄色的戈壁[¶]，一直伸到天边。偶尔有几棵矮矮的树站在路边，像几个走丢了的人。林秋拿出速写本，想把它画下来，可是画了几笔就停了。这么大的地方，这么空，她不知道该从哪里画起。

5 火车到敦煌[*]的时候，已经是晚上八点多了，可是天还亮着。

† 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou, capital of Gansu
‡ 秋秋 *Qiūqiu* Qiuqiu, Lin Qiu's pet name
§ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
¶ 戈壁 *gēbì* gobi, stony desert
* 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang, city in Gansu

After the train left Lanzhou, her mother called again. "Qiuqiu, it's not too late to change your mind," said her mother. "However much you love painting, you don't have to run off to the desert to do it." Lin Qiu laughed. "Mum, I'm not going to paint pictures, I'm going to repair them." "Repair them? Isn't that just painting?" Lin Qiu thought for a moment and didn't answer. In fact she wasn't quite sure herself what the difference between the two really was. 3

The view from the window grew more and more monotonous. At first there were still villages and green fields to see; later there was only greyish-yellow gobi, stretching all the way to the horizon. Now and then a few low trees stood beside the line, like people who had wandered off and got lost. Lin Qiu took out her sketchbook and wanted to draw it, but after a few strokes she stopped. A place so big, so empty: she didn't know where to begin. 4

When the train reached Dunhuang it was past eight in the evening, but the sky was still light. 5

来接她的是一个年轻人，叫小周[1]，比她早来三年，也是修壁画[2]的。小周开着一辆旧车，带她往莫高窟[3]去。“莫高窟离城里大约二十五公里，”他一边开车一边说，“以后你就住在那儿，进一次城可不容易。”

车开到莫高窟的时候，太阳正好落到鸣沙山[4]后面。林秋[5]看见一面长长的山崖[6]，山崖上有密密麻麻[7]的洞口，一层一层的，仿佛一个巨大的蜂窝[8]。“一共有七百多个洞窟[9]，”小周说，“其中有壁画和彩塑[10]的，大约有四百九十个。”“据说最早的洞窟是一千六百多年前开始挖的，最晚的是元朝[11]的，前后差不多一千年。”“这么多壁画……”林秋小声说。“有人算过，要是把这里的壁画一张一张排起来，大约有二十五公里长，”小周笑了，“跟我们刚才走的路差不多。”

1 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou
2 壁画 *bìhuà* mural
3 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves, Dunhuang
4 鸣沙山 *Míngshā Shān* Mingsha (Singing Sands) Mountain
5 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
6 山崖 *shānyá* cliff
7 密密麻麻 *mìmimámá* dense and numerous
8 蜂窝 *fēngwō* honeycomb
9 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
10 彩塑 *cǎisù* painted clay sculpture
11 元朝 *Yuáncháo* Yuan dynasty (1271–1368)

The person who came to meet her was a young man called Xiao Zhou, who had arrived three years before her and also repaired murals. Xiao Zhou drove her towards Mogao in an old car. "Mogao is about twenty-five kilometres from town," he said as he drove. "From now on you'll live out there, and getting into town isn't easy." 5

When the car reached Mogao, the sun was just going down behind Mingsha Mountain. Lin Qiu saw a long cliff face crowded with cave openings, tier upon tier, like an enormous honeycomb. "There are over seven hundred caves in all," said Xiao Zhou. "About four hundred and ninety of them have murals and painted sculptures." "They say the earliest caves were begun more than 1,600 years ago, and the latest date from the Yuan dynasty, nearly a thousand years apart." "So many murals..." Lin Qiu said softly. "Somebody once worked out that if you laid all the murals here side by side, they'd stretch about twenty-five kilometres," Xiao Zhou said with a smile. "About as far as the road we just drove." 6

7 那天晚上，林秋[†]躺在宿舍的小床上，很久很久都睡不着。窗外特别安静，只有风吹着沙子的声音。她想，明天，她就可以走进那些洞窟[‡]了。她把速写本放在床头，想把明天看到的第一个飞天[§]画下来。她想错了。

第一面墙

8 第二天早上，小周[¶]没有带她去洞窟，而是带她去了院子后面的一间大屋子。屋子里立着好几面墙，墙上画着佛像[*]、图案和飞天，颜色有深有浅。林秋走近一看，就发现了问题：这些画上到处都是伤。有的地方，颜色一片一片地卷了起来；有的地方，墙皮像饼干一样碎了；还有的地方，用手指轻轻一敲，里面就“咚咚[#]”地响，好像是空的。

† 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
‡ 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
§ 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
¶ 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou
* 佛像 *fóxiàng* Buddha figure
咚咚 *dōngdōng* thud, hollow knock

That night Lin Qiu lay on the narrow bed in her dormitory and lay awake for a long, long time. Outside it was very quiet, with only the sound of the wind blowing sand. Tomorrow, she thought, she would be able to walk into those caves. She put her sketchbook by her pillow, meaning to draw the first flying apsara she saw. She was wrong. 7

The First Wall

The next morning Xiao Zhou didn't take her to the caves; instead he took her to a big room behind the courtyard. In the room stood several walls painted with Buddha figures, patterns and flying apsaras, in deep and pale colours. As soon as Lin Qiu came closer, she saw the problem: these paintings were wounded all over. In some places the paint had curled up flake by flake; in others the plaster had crumbled like a biscuit; and in others, when you tapped lightly with a finger, it gave a hollow knock, as if there were nothing inside. 8

9 “这些是试验墙，”小周[1]说，“是按照洞窟[2]里的老办法做的。”“先在石头上抹[3]一层粗泥，泥里加麦草；再抹一层细泥，刷一层白色，最后才画画。”“然后，我们再想办法让它们‘生病’。”“为什么要让它们生病？”“因为你得先在假的墙上练，练到手不抖[4]了，才能碰真的。”“要练多久？”小周想了想：“看人。我练了一年。”林秋[5]以为他在开玩笑。后来她才知道，他没有。

10 她的第一个任务，是处理一小块“起甲[6]”的地方。起甲，就是颜料层从墙上卷起来，像鱼身上的鳞片[7]一样，风一吹就会掉下来。修的办法听起来很简单：用很细的针管，把一点点胶水打到每一片颜料的下面，等它稍微干一点儿，再用一个包着软布的小工具，把颜料轻轻压回墙上。可是真做起来，一点儿也不简单。

1 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou
2 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
3 抹 *mǒ* to spread, to plaster
4 抖 *dǒu* to tremble
5 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
6 起甲 *qǐjiǎ* flaking (of paint layer)
7 鳞片 *línpiàn* scale (of a fish)

"These are test walls," said Xiao Zhou. "They're made the old way, like the walls in the caves." "First you spread a layer of coarse mud mixed with wheat straw on the rock; then a layer of fine mud and a coat of white; and only then do you paint." "After that, we find ways to make them 'fall ill'." "Why make them ill?" "Because you have to practise on fake walls first. Only when your hands stop shaking can you touch the real ones." "How long do you have to practise?" Xiao Zhou thought about it. "Depends on the person. I practised for a year." Lin Qiu thought he was joking. Only later did she learn that he wasn't. 9

Her first task was to treat a small patch of "flaking". Flaking is when the paint layer lifts away from the wall like the scales on a fish, ready to fall off at the first breath of wind. The method sounds simple: with a very fine syringe, put a tiny drop of adhesive under each flake of paint, wait for it to dry a little, then use a small tool wrapped in soft cloth to press the paint gently back onto the wall. But actually doing it was not simple at all. 10

10 胶水多了，画面上会留下亮亮的印子；胶水少了，颜料粘[†]不住。压得太轻，没有用；压得太重，颜料就碎成了粉末。第一天，林秋[‡]一共修了不到两个指甲大的地方，却已经压碎了好几片颜料。

11 第二个星期，第二个月，她照样每天坐在那面墙前面。她的同学们在网上发自己的画展[§]和新作品，她能拍的，只有墙上那块一天比一天小的“伤口”。有一天晚上，她在电话里对妈妈说：“我觉得自己不像一个学画的人，倒像一个……补墙的。”妈妈在那边沉默了一会儿，说：“那你就回来吧。”林秋却说：“再等等。”为什么要等，她自己也说不清楚。也许是因为不想认输，也许是因为她还没有见过真正的洞窟[¶]。

† 粘 *zhān* to stick
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 画展 *huàzhǎn* art exhibition
¶ 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)

Too much adhesive left shiny marks on the picture; too little, and the paint wouldn't stick. Press too lightly and it did nothing; press too hard and the paint crumbled to powder. On the first day Lin Qiu repaired an area smaller than two fingernails, and had already crushed several flakes. 10

In the second week, and in the second month, she still sat in front of that wall every day. Her classmates posted their exhibitions and new work online; all she had to photograph was the "wound" on the wall, a little smaller each day. One evening she said to her mother on the phone, "I don't feel like someone who studied painting. I feel more like a... wall-patcher." Her mother was silent for a moment at the other end, then said, "Then come home." But Lin Qiu said, "Let me wait a bit longer." Why she wanted to wait, she couldn't say herself. Perhaps because she didn't want to admit defeat; perhaps because she still hadn't seen a real cave. 11

马老师

12 带她的师傅姓马，大家都叫他马老师。马老师是八十年代中期来莫高窟[†]的，那年他才二十岁，是从甘肃[‡]的一个小县城来的。他个子不高，很瘦，脸被太阳晒得又黑又红，手指上总有洗不掉的泥。他很少说话，就算说，也往往只有几个字：“重来。”“太快了。”“再看看。”

13 林秋[§]来了三个月，从来没有听他说过一个“好”字。有一次，她花了一整个下午，修好了一块鸡蛋大的起甲[¶]，自己觉得很满意，就请马老师来看。马老师拿起放大镜，看了很久，然后指着一个几乎看不见的发亮的小点说：“这儿，胶多了。”“就一点点，”林秋说，“别人根本看不出来。”“别人看不出来，墙照样知道。”马老师说。

† 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves, Dunhuang
‡ 甘肃 *Gānsù* Gansu Province
§ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
¶ 起甲 *qǐjiǎ* flaking (of paint layer)

Teacher Ma

The master who trained her was surnamed Ma, and everyone called him 12
Teacher Ma. Teacher Ma had come to Mogao in the mid-1980s, when he was only twenty, from a small county town in Gansu. He was short and very thin, his face burned dark red by the sun, and there was always earth on his fingers that wouldn't wash off. He seldom spoke, and even when he did, it was often only a few words: "Again." "Too fast." "Look again."

Lin Qiu had been there three months and had never once heard him say 13
"good". Once she spent a whole afternoon repairing a patch of flaking the size of an egg. She was pleased with it and asked Teacher Ma to come and look. Teacher Ma picked up a magnifying glass and looked for a long time, then pointed at a tiny shiny spot that was almost invisible. "Here. Too much glue." "It's only a tiny bit," said Lin Qiu. "Nobody else would ever notice." "Nobody else may notice, but the wall knows all the same," said Teacher Ma.

13 “你今天多打的这一点胶，五十年以后可能就变成一块黄色的印子。到那时候我们都不在了，谁替你改？”林秋[†]不说话了。那天晚上，她把那块地方重新修了一遍。

14 后来，她从小周[‡]那里听到了一些马老师的事。马老师刚来的时候，莫高窟[§]的条件很差。大家住在土房子里，冬天屋里冷得像冰一样，夏天风一刮，碗里都是沙子。听说那时候附近河里的水又苦又咸，可是没有别的水，只好喝。跟他一起来的几个年轻人，有的干了两年就走了，有的结婚以后调回了城里。马老师留了下来，一留就是将近四十年。

15 有一天吃午饭的时候，林秋终于忍不住问他：“马老师，您修了这么多年的壁画[¶]，有没有哪一幅是您最得意的？”

† 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
‡ 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou
§ 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves, Dunhuang
¶ 壁画 *bìhuà* mural

"That extra bit of glue you put in today could turn into a yellow stain fifty years from now. By then neither of us will be around. Who's going to correct it for you?" Lin Qiu said no more. That evening she repaired the patch all over again. 13

Later she heard a few things about Teacher Ma from Xiao Zhou. When Teacher Ma first came, conditions at Mogao were very poor. People lived in mud houses. In winter the rooms were as cold as ice, and in summer, whenever the wind blew, their bowls filled with sand. It's said that the river water nearby was bitter and salty back then, but there was no other water, so they had to drink it. Of the young people who came with him, some left after two years, and some were transferred back to the cities after they married. Teacher Ma stayed, and once he stayed, he stayed for nearly forty years. 14

One day at lunch, Lin Qiu finally couldn't help asking him, "Teacher Ma, you've repaired murals for so many years. Is there one you're proudest of?" 15

15 马老师放下筷子，想了一会儿，说：“修壁画[†]的人，最好的作品，就是让人看不出来我们来过。”林秋[‡]没听懂。“我们不是画家，”马老师说，“颜色掉了的地方，我们不补画；看不清楚的地方，我们也不替古人[§]画清楚。”“我们只做一件事：让还在墙上的，继续留在墙上。这叫‘修旧如旧[¶]’。”“那……就算我画得再好，也没有用吗？”“有用。”马老师说，“画得好的人，才知道哪一笔不能碰。”

盐和沙

16 到了第二年春天，马老师终于带她进了洞窟[*]。洞里很暗，也很凉。马老师打开手电筒[#]，一道光照到墙上，林秋一下子屏住了呼吸。

† 壁画 *bìhuà* mural
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 古人 *gǔrén* the ancients
¶ 修旧如旧 *xiūjiù rújiù* restore the old as old
* 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
手电筒 *shǒudiàntǒng* torch, flashlight

Teacher Ma put down his chopsticks, thought for a while, and said, "For some- 15
one who repairs murals, the best work is the kind where no one can tell we were ever there." Lin Qiu didn't understand. "We aren't painters," said Teacher Ma. "Where the colour has fallen away, we don't paint it back; where things are unclear, we don't make them clear on the ancients' behalf." "We do one thing only: keep what is still on the wall on the wall. That's called 'restoring the old as old'." "Then... even if I paint really well, it's no use at all?" "It's of use," said Teacher Ma. "Only someone who paints well knows which brushstroke must not be touched."

Salt and Sand

In the spring of her second year, Teacher Ma at last took her into the caves. 16
Inside it was dark and cool. Teacher Ma switched on his torch; a beam of light fell on the wall, and Lin Qiu caught her breath.

16 墙上画满了人：坐着的佛，站着的菩萨[†]，弹琴的、跳舞的、骑马的，还有在天上飞的。他们衣服的颜色那么鲜艳，仿佛是昨天才画上去的。可是马老师把光移到墙的下面，林秋[‡]就看见了另一种样子。那里的墙皮变得又松又软，一层一层地往下掉，地上有一小堆白色的粉末。

17 “这是酥碱[§]，”马老师说，“是盐弄的。”他告诉林秋，敦煌[¶]的石头和泥土[*]里本来就有很多盐。平时天气干，盐老老实实地待在墙里，什么事也没有。可是一旦空气变湿，比如下了一场难得的雨，或者洞里一下子进来很多人，盐就会化在水里，跟着水分慢慢跑到墙的表面。等空气又变干了，水走了，盐却留了下来，变成一颗一颗小小的结晶[#]。“结晶会长大，会往外推，”马老师说，“它一推，颜料就掉了，泥就松了。一年推几次，几百年下来，一面墙就成了这个样子。”

† 菩萨 *púsà* bodhisattva
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 酥碱 *sūjiǎn* salt crumbling (of plaster)
¶ 敦煌 *Dūnhuáng* Dunhuang, city in Gansu
* 泥土 *nítǔ* earth, soil
\# 结晶 *jiéjīng* crystal

The wall was covered with figures: seated Buddhas, standing bodhisattvas, 16
people playing instruments, dancing, riding horses, and some flying in the sky. The colours of their clothes were so vivid, it was as if they had been painted only yesterday. But when Teacher Ma moved the light to the lower part of the wall, Lin Qiu saw something quite different. There the plaster had grown loose and soft and was falling away layer by layer; on the floor lay a little heap of white powder.

"This is salt damage," said Teacher Ma. "The salt did this." He told Lin 17
Qiu that Dunhuang's rock and soil naturally contain a lot of salt. Normally the weather is dry, and the salt stays quietly in the wall without causing any trouble. But once the air turns damp, say after one of the rare rains, or when a lot of people suddenly come into a cave, the salt dissolves and slowly travels with the moisture to the surface of the wall. When the air dries out again, the water leaves but the salt stays behind, turning into tiny crystals. "The crystals grow and push outwards," said Teacher Ma. "Every push, a bit of paint falls off and the mud loosens. A few pushes a year, for a few hundred years, and a wall ends up like this."

18 “人也会让洞里变湿吗？”“当然。人要呼吸，呼出来的气里有水，也有热量。”“一个人不算什么，可是一个小洞窟[†]里同时站着几十个人，过一会儿，湿度[‡]和温度就上去了。”马老师说，所以现在参观莫高窟[§]要提前预约，每天进来的人数有限制。洞窟也不是天天开放，而是轮流[¶]开放，从而让每一面墙都能“休息”一下。“有的游客不高兴，说花了钱，才看了几个洞。”马老师说，“可是这些画已经被人看了一千多年了，它们也会累的。”

19 除了盐，还有沙。莫高窟背后就是鸣沙山[*]，风一大，沙子就从山上流下来，堆在洞口，有时候还会打在壁画[#]上。马老师说，以前下面的一些洞窟差点儿被沙子埋掉。这些年，人们在山上用草扎了很多方格，又拉起了挡沙的网，吹到洞口的沙子比以前少多了。

† 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
‡ 湿度 *shīdù* humidity
§ 莫高窟 *Mògāokū* Mogao Caves, Dunhuang
¶ 轮流 *lúnliú* to take turns
* 鸣沙山 *Míngshā Shān* Mingsha (Singing Sands) Mountain
壁画 *bìhuà* mural

"Can people make a cave damp too?" "Of course. People breathe, and the 18
air they breathe out carries water, and heat too." "One person is nothing, but put a few dozen people in a small cave at the same time and before long the humidity and temperature go up." That was why, Teacher Ma said, visits to Mogao now had to be booked in advance, and the number of visitors each day was limited. Nor were the caves all open every day; they opened in turns, so that every wall could get a little "rest". "Some visitors are unhappy. They say they paid good money and only saw a handful of caves," said Teacher Ma. "But people have been looking at these paintings for more than a thousand years. They get tired too."

Besides salt, there was sand. Right behind Mogao is Mingsha Mountain. 19
When the wind is strong, sand pours down from it and piles up at the cave mouths, and sometimes it even blasts against the murals. Teacher Ma said that in the past some of the lower caves had nearly been buried by sand. In recent years people had laid out grids of bound straw on the dunes above and put up sand fences, and much less sand now blew down to the caves.

19 “尽管这样，”他说，“每天早上，我们还是要先扫一遍沙子，再开始干活。”林秋[1]听了，第一次觉得，自己练了一年的那些“补墙”的功夫，好像有了意义。

一个飞天[2]

20 那年秋天，马老师接到一个任务：修一个唐代[3]小洞窟[4]里的飞天。他只带了林秋一个人。这个飞天不大，从头到脚还没有一张桌子长。她侧着身体，一只手托着一盘花，长长的衣带向后飞起，仿佛风正从她身边吹过。她的脸是黑的。马老师说，这不是画工[5]本来用的颜色。人们认为，有些颜料里有铅[6]，时间长了会慢慢变黑。很多壁画[7]上黑色的脸，一千多年前也许是白里透红[8]的。

1 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
2 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
3 唐代 *Tángdài* Tang dynasty (618–907)
4 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
5 画工 *huàgōng* (ancient) painter, artisan
6 铅 *qiān* lead (metal)
7 壁画 *bìhuà* mural
8 白里透红 *báilǐ tòuhóng* rosy and fair

"Even so," he said, "every morning we still have to sweep away the sand first 19
before we start work." Listening to him, Lin Qiu felt for the first time that the "wall-patching" skills she had spent a year practising might have some meaning after all.

One Flying Apsara

That autumn Teacher Ma was given a task: to repair a flying apsara in a 20
small Tang-dynasty cave. He took only Lin Qiu with him. The apsara wasn't big; from head to foot she was shorter than a table. She was turned to one side, holding up a plate of flowers on one hand, her long ribbons flying out behind her, as if the wind were rushing past her at that very moment. Her face was black. Teacher Ma said this wasn't the colour the painter had originally used. People believe that some pigments contain lead, which slowly turns black over time. Many of the black faces in the murals may well have been fair and rosy a thousand years ago.

21 这个飞天[1]病得很重。她身上的颜料起甲[2]起得很厉害，一碰就会掉。衣带下面还有一块墙皮已经“空鼓”[3]了，跟后面的石头分开了，随时可能整块掉下来。“起甲掉了，掉的只是几片颜色；”马老师说，“空鼓一旦掉下来，就是一整块画，再也回不去了。”

22 他们在洞里搭了一个小架子[4]，每天早上八点进洞，下午五点出来。马老师先处理空鼓。他在墙皮边上找到几个早就有的小裂口，从那里把一种特别调的泥浆[5]慢慢送进去，让墙皮和石头重新“长”在一起。林秋[6]负责起甲。她用的还是那支最细的针管，还是那个包着软布的小工具，可是这一次，手下的颜料是一千多年前的。她的手又开始抖[7]了。“手抖没关系，别急。”马老师在旁边说，“呼吸慢一点儿，跟你在试验墙上练的时候一样。”

1 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
2 起甲 *qǐjiǎ* flaking (of paint layer)
3 空鼓 *kōnggǔ* hollowing (plaster detaching)
4 架子 *jiàzi* frame, scaffold
5 泥浆 *níjiāng* slurry, grout
6 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
7 抖 *dǒu* to tremble

This apsara was very ill. The paint on her body was flaking badly and would 21
fall off at a touch. Beneath her ribbons, a piece of plaster had already "hollowed": it had come away from the rock behind it and could drop off in one piece at any moment. "When flaking falls, you lose a few flakes of colour," said Teacher Ma. "But once a hollowed patch comes down, it's a whole piece of the painting, and there's no getting it back."

They put up a small scaffold in the cave, went in at eight every morning and 22
came out at five in the afternoon. Teacher Ma dealt with the hollowing first. At the edge of the plaster he found a few small cracks that had been there a long time, and through them he slowly fed in a specially mixed grout, so that the plaster and the rock would "grow" back together. Lin Qiu was in charge of the flaking. She was using the same finest syringe and the same little tool wrapped in soft cloth, but this time the paint under her hand was more than a thousand years old. Her hands began to shake again. "Shaking hands don't matter. Don't rush," said Teacher Ma beside her. "Breathe more slowly, just as you did when you practised on the test wall."

23 就这样，他们一天一天地做下去。顺利的时候，一天能修好一块手心大的地方；不顺利的时候，一整天只修了几片指甲大的颜料。外面的树叶黄了，又落了。下第一场雪的时候，飞天[†]的衣带才修了一半。林秋[‡]常常觉得，自己好像已经在这个小小的洞里住了很多年。她闭上眼睛，也能画出飞天的每一根线：哪里粗，哪里细，哪一笔是画工[§]犹豫过、又改过的。

24 有一天下午，她在修飞天手边的一小块地方时，突然在颜料上发现了一个小小的指纹[¶]。指纹很浅，一半在花盘上，一半在衣带上，大概是画工在颜料还没干的时候，不小心碰了一下。“马老师，您看！”马老师走过来，看了很久，没有说话。后来他说：“我修了快四十年的画，这样的东西也只见过几次。”“画这个飞天的人，可能是个年轻人，跟你差不多大。他没有留下名字，只留下了这个。”

† 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 画工 *huàgōng* (ancient) painter, artisan
¶ 指纹 *zhǐwén* fingerprint

And so they worked on, day after day. On good days they could finish a patch the size of a palm; on bad days a whole day's work came to a few flakes the size of a fingernail. Outside, the leaves turned yellow and fell. By the time the first snow fell, only half of the apsara's ribbons had been done. Lin Qiu often felt as though she had been living in that tiny cave for years. Even with her eyes closed she could draw every line of the apsara: where it was thick, where it was thin, which stroke the painter had hesitated over and then changed. 23

One afternoon, while working on a small patch beside the apsara's hand, she suddenly found a tiny fingerprint in the paint. It was faint, half on the plate of flowers and half on the ribbon; perhaps the painter had brushed against it by accident while the paint was still wet. "Teacher Ma, look!" Teacher Ma came over and looked for a long time without saying a word. At last he said, "I've been repairing paintings for nearly forty years, and I've only seen something like this a few times." "Whoever painted this apsara may have been young, about your age. He didn't leave his name; he only left this." 24

24 林秋[†]把自己的手指放在指纹[‡]旁边，没有碰它。两个手指之间，隔着一千多年。那一刻，她想：画画的人可以不小心留下一个指纹；修画的人，却连一个指纹也不能留下。

25 修完最后一片颜料的时候，已经是第二年的三月。马老师关了别的灯，只留一个，让光从旁边照过去。飞天[§]还是那个飞天：脸还是黑的，掉了颜色的地方还是空的，看上去跟半年前几乎一样。可是林秋知道，她不会再掉了。至少在她们活着的时候，不会。“修了半年，看上去跟没修一样。”林秋说完，自己先笑了。马老师也笑了，这是她第一次看见他笑：“这就对了。”

† 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu

‡ 指纹 *zhǐwén* fingerprint

§ 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)

Lin Qiu held her own finger beside the print, without touching it. Between the two fingers lay more than a thousand years. At that moment she thought: the one who paints may leave a fingerprint by accident; the one who repairs must not leave even one. 24

By the time they had fixed the last flake, it was March of the following year. Teacher Ma switched off the other lamps, leaving just one, so that the light fell across the wall from the side. The apsara was the same apsara: her face was still black, the places where the colour had gone were still blank, and she looked almost exactly as she had half a year before. But Lin Qiu knew she would not fall now. Not in their lifetimes, at least. "Half a year's work, and it looks as if we never touched it." Lin Qiu laughed at her own words. Teacher Ma smiled too; it was the first time she had seen him smile. "That's exactly right." 25

照相机里的洞窟[1]

26 飞天[2]修好以后，小周[3]带林秋[4]去看了另一个小组的工作。在一个洞窟里，几个年轻人推着一个装着相机的架子[5]，沿着墙一点一点地移动，每移动一点儿，就拍一张。“一个洞窟要拍几千张，甚至几万张照片，”小周说，“然后用电脑把它们拼在一起，从而得到一张非常清楚的大图。放大以后，连颜料上的小裂口都看得见。”这就是“数字敦煌[6]”。

27 据说，敦煌研究院[7]从上个世纪八九十年代就开始想办法给洞窟拍下这样的照片了。大约从2016年开始，第一批三十个左右洞窟的高清照片放到了网上。从此，世界上任何一个地方的人，只要打开电脑或者手机，就可以“走进”这些洞窟，慢慢地看。

1 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
2 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
3 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou
4 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
5 架子 *jiàzi* frame, scaffold
6 数字敦煌 *Shùzì Dūnhuáng* Digital Dunhuang project
7 敦煌研究院 *Dūnhuáng Yánjiūyuàn* Dunhuang Academy

Caves Inside a Camera

After the apsara was finished, Xiao Zhou took Lin Qiu to see the work of another team. In one cave a few young people were pushing a frame with a camera on it, moving it along the wall little by little and taking a picture at every tiny move. "One cave takes thousands, even tens of thousands, of photos," said Xiao Zhou. "Then the computer stitches them together, and that gives you one huge, very sharp picture. Zoom in, and you can even see the tiny cracks in the paint." This was "Digital Dunhuang". 26

It is said that the Dunhuang Academy had begun looking for ways to photograph the caves like this as early as the 1980s and 90s. From around 2016, high-definition images of a first group of about thirty caves were put online. From then on, anyone anywhere in the world could open a computer or a phone, "walk into" these caves and take their time looking. 27

27 现在，很多游客进洞以前，也会先在山下的展示中心看一部关于洞窟[†]的电影。他们在洞里待的时间短了，墙也轻松了一些。

28 那天晚上，林秋[‡]给妈妈发了一个链接[§]。过了一个小时，妈妈打来电话，声音有点儿激动：“秋秋[¶]，我看见了！就是你说的那个飞天[*]，手里托着一盘花的，对不对？”“那是我修的。”林秋说。“可是我什么也没看出来呀。”“对，”林秋说，“看不出来，就说明修好了。”妈妈在电话那头沉默了一会儿，说：“你们这个工作，真奇怪。”

29 可是林秋心里也有了一个问题。既然照片能把每一根线、每一块颜色都保存下来，那么一百年以后，就算墙上的画真的没了，人们也照样可以在电脑里看到它。那她们每天跪在洞里修的那一点一点，还有多大意义？

† 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 链接 *liànjiē* (web) link
¶ 秋秋 *Qiūqiu* Qiuqiu, Lin Qiu's pet name
* 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)

Nowadays many visitors also watch a film about the caves at a visitor centre before they go in. They spend less time inside, and the walls get a little relief. 27

That evening Lin Qiu sent her mother a link. An hour later her mother called, sounding a little excited. "Qiuqiu, I saw it! That apsara you told me about, the one holding a plate of flowers, right?" "I repaired that," said Lin Qiu. "But I couldn't see anything." "Exactly," said Lin Qiu. "If you can't see it, that means it was done right." Her mother was quiet at the other end for a moment, then said, "That job of yours is really strange." 28

But Lin Qiu now had a question of her own. If photographs could preserve every line and every patch of colour, then a hundred years from now, even if the paintings on the walls were really gone, people could still see them on a computer. Then what was the point of the tiny bits they repaired every day, kneeling in the caves? 29

29 她把这个问题告诉了马老师。马老师想了很久，说：“照片是画的影子，不是画。”“你在网上看飞天[†]，看到的是光。你在洞里看飞天，看到的是墙、是泥、是麦草，是一千多年前一个年轻人的手指。”“照片拍得再清楚，墙也照样会老。拍照片，是为了万一有一天保不住了，还能留下点儿什么；修墙，是为了不让那一天来得太早。”“两件事，缺一不可[‡]。”

留下

30 又过了一年，马老师到了退休的年龄。他的女儿在兰州[§]工作，早就希望他过去一起住。同一个月，林秋[¶]也接到了一个电话。是她大学的老师打来的，说上海[*]一家博物馆在招人，工作轻松，离家也近，问她想不想去试试。

† 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)
‡ 缺一不可 *quēyī bùkě* neither can be done without
§ 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou, capital of Gansu
¶ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
* 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

She put the question to Teacher Ma. Teacher Ma thought for a long time and said, "A photograph is the painting's shadow, not the painting." "When you look at the apsara online, what you see is light. When you look at her in the cave, you see the wall, the mud, the straw, and the finger of a young man from more than a thousand years ago." "However sharp the photograph, the wall will still grow old. We take photographs so that if one day we can't save it, something will be left; we repair the wall so that day doesn't come too soon." "We need both. Neither will do without the other." 29

Staying

Another year went by, and Teacher Ma reached retirement age. His daughter worked in Lanzhou and had long wanted him to come and live with her. That same month, Lin Qiu got a phone call too. It was one of her university teachers: a museum in Shanghai was hiring, the work was easy and it was close to home. Would she like to give it a try? 30

30 “你已经在沙漠里待了三年了，”老师说，“尽管这段经历很宝贵，可是年轻人总要为自己的将来想一想。”妈妈知道以后，更是天天打电话来。林秋[†]没有马上回答。

31 马老师走的前一天晚上，把林秋叫到他的小屋里。桌上放着一个旧木头盒子，里面是几支针管，几把小刀，和一本厚厚的本子。“这是我这些年修过的每一块墙的记录：哪个洞，什么病，用的什么胶，后来有没有再坏。”“修墙的人会走，墙会留下来。下一个人来修的时候，得知道上一个人做过什么。”他把盒子推到林秋面前：“我不是要你留下。你还年轻，去哪儿都好。这个盒子，你带走也行，留给下一个人也行。”

32 第二天早上，林秋和小周[‡]开车送马老师去火车站。窗外还是她第一次来时见过的那片戈壁[§]，一直伸到天边。三年前，她觉得这里什么都没有。

† 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu

‡ 小周 *Xiǎo Zhōu* Xiao Zhou

§ 戈壁 *gēbì* gobi, stony desert

"You've already spent three years in the desert," the teacher said. "That experience is precious, but a young person has to think about her own future." Once her mother heard, she phoned every single day. Lin Qiu didn't answer right away. 30

The evening before Teacher Ma left, he called Lin Qiu to his little room. On the table was an old wooden box. Inside were a few syringes, a few small knives and a thick notebook. "This is a record of every patch of wall I've repaired over the years: which cave, what disease, what glue I used, and whether it went bad again later." "The people who repair walls leave; the walls stay. When the next person comes to repair them, they need to know what the last one did." He pushed the box across to her. "I'm not asking you to stay. You're young; wherever you go is fine. As for this box, take it with you or leave it for the next person, either way." 31

The next morning Lin Qiu and Xiao Zhou drove Teacher Ma to the station. Outside the window was the same gobi she had seen when she first came, stretching all the way to the horizon. Three years ago she had thought there was nothing here. 32

32 现在她知道，在那面山崖[†]里，有几万平方米的墙，每一面都在慢慢变老，每一面都在等人。火车开以前，马老师从窗口伸出头来，只说了三个字：“别着急。”林秋[‡]不知道他说的是修画，还是别的什么。

33 那天晚上，林秋给大学的老师回了电话，谢谢他，说她不去上海[§]了。然后她给妈妈打电话：“妈，就算再过十年，我可能也还是一个补墙的。”电话那头很久没有声音。最后，妈妈叹了一口气：“那你冬天多穿点儿。”

34 第二天早上八点，林秋照样走进了那个小洞窟[¶]。她打开灯，飞天[*]还在那里，侧着身体，衣带向后飞起，仿佛马上就要飞走了。林秋翻开马老师的本子，在最后一页上写下了今天的日期，和自己的名字。以后会有人记得这个名字吗？她不知道。

† 山崖 *shānyá* cliff
‡ 林秋 *Lín Qiū* Lin Qiu
§ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
¶ 洞窟 *dòngkū* cave (temple)
* 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)

Now she knew that inside that cliff were tens of thousands of square metres of wall, every one of them slowly growing old, every one of them waiting for someone. Before the train pulled out, Teacher Ma leaned out of the window and said just three words: "Don't rush it." Lin Qiu couldn't tell whether he meant the paintings, or something else. 32

That evening Lin Qiu called her university teacher back, thanked him, and said she wouldn't be going to Shanghai. Then she called her mother. "Mum, even ten years from now, I'll probably still be a wall-patcher." For a long time there was no sound at the other end. At last her mother sighed. "Then wear more layers in winter." 33

At eight the next morning, Lin Qiu walked into the little cave as usual. She switched on the light. The apsara was still there, turned to one side, ribbons streaming behind her, as if she were about to fly away. Lin Qiu opened Teacher Ma's notebook and wrote the date on the last page, and her own name. Would anyone remember that name one day? She didn't know. 34

34 也许不会，就像没有人知道画飞天†的人叫什么一样。可是飞天还在飞。

† 飞天 *fēitiān* flying apsara (celestial figure)

Perhaps not, just as no one knows the name of the person who painted the apsara. But the apsara is still flying. 34